called because of the pilgrim ships that set off for the hajj from this port. The Portuguese authorities were known to harass the hajj ships and Akbar now needed to ensure that pilgrims would be safe. Extraordinary attention, it was clarified, had to be paid to the vessel which would be carrying the imperial family to Mecca. It is very possible that the persons being singled out in this way were Gulbadan and her party of Mughal women, who would leave for the hajj in 1575. In return, Akbar gave the Portuguese important tax concessions and instructed Mughal officials in the area not to harass the Portuguese merchants.

As the siege of Surat continued, Akbar met with another interesting local personality, the Parsee priest Dastur Meherji Rana. Akbar questioned the priest about his religion and traditions and the man, stately in his spotless white robes and long white beard, made a favourable impression on the Padshah.

Surat was captured and occupied easily and the imperial train settled into the city to administer its affairs. One evening when Akbar was enjoying a round of drinks with a select group of noblemen, some of the Rajput warriors began regaling the audience with tales of exemplary Rajput heroism. To settle issues of rivalry, they claimed, a rather unusual method was followed: someone would be deputed to hold a double-headed spear steady, and then the two contending Rajput men would charge at the weapon from either end ‘so that the latter would transfix them and come out at their backs’. Piqued by talk of this admittedly insane act of physical prowess, Akbar immediately fixed his own sword in a wall and ‘declared that if Rajputs were wont to sell their valour in their way, he too could rush against this sword’. Immediately sobered, the assembly watched in horrified silence until Man Singh rushed at the sword and flung it away, injuring Akbar’s hand. The enraged Padshah threw Man Singh upon the ground and began beating him roundly until one of the courtiers pulled him off. Akbar’s wound healed, we are told, and he would reserve further feats of bravery for the battlefield.

Surat, on the banks of the river Tapti, was already a large and prosperous town. Manuel Godinho, a later traveller and writer, remarked about the houses of the Muslim noblemen that ‘the best of these houses from the roadside look like hell but once you enter them, they seem like paradise, because they are laced all over with gold, with magnificent paintings on their ceilings…’ The Hindu ‘baniyas’, on the other hand, ‘build